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MOTIVATIONAL RACE BIB KIT

Abstract

The present invention relates to a reversible and customizable name bib kit and set of supplies, which provides improved functionality and utility in the field of sporting events, particularly running races, marathons, and other competitive activities. This kit or set of supplies, referred to as the “Motivational Race Bib Kit,” incorporates supplies to enhance the participant's experience, and streamline race management processes.

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Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS [0001] This application claims the benefit of priority of U.S. provisional application No. 63/559,444, filed Feb. 29, 2024, and claims the benefit of priority of U.S. provisional application No. 63/685,785, filed Aug. 22, 2024, the contents of which are each herein incorporated by reference.

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

[0002] The present invention relates generally to race bibs for use in sporting competitions where race bibs are visible on the athlete's body. More specifically, the present invention relates to re-configurable, reversible, alphanumeric adhesive decals (or other alphanumeric display methods) on a waterproof and tear proof bib (or other display method), designed to be attached to an athlete's body or on a shirt/jersey during a sporting event.

[0003] Sporting events, such as running races and marathons, have gained immense popularity in recent years, attracting not only participants but also spectators. Participants of these events have increasingly used the garments and decorations on their body to give them motivation.

[0004] Sporting apparel originated back in ancient, medieval times. Sports attire in ancient civilizations like Greece and Rome was minimal, often just loincloths, to allow for freedom of movement. Additionally, in medieval times, sports such as jousting had armor as 'apparel,' serving protective rather than motivational purposes. In the late 1800's this changed dramatically because of the industrial revolution. Materials like wool and cotton were more and easier to access and so materials for sporting apparel also evolved with this expansion of material access. This is also when uniforms for teams became more common.

[0005] In the early to mid-20th century, sporting apparel became common, but the offerings were more functionality over form. The inventions of shorts and t-shirts became more widely used for sports like running. Then with the invention of nylon and more flexible type fabrics, comfort and form were better accommodated.

[0006] In the 1970's and 80's, more athletic brands became popular, like Nike and Reebok. This created a boom for commercialization of sports apparel and provided consumers with a plethora of options on how to dress for sport.

[0007] Now in the 20th century, personalization and customization has become very important for the consumer. Consumers look to their attire more to express themselves and feel like they can add personal touches to express the athlete's identity. It has been shown that there are psychological benefits of consumers feeling like their apparel reflects their identity and can provide them a channel of expression by wearing apparel of their choice. Individualized expression has shown that it increases motivation and confidence and potentially increases performance during sports activity.

[0008] Conventional products and methods differ from the present invention. For example, US20230218972 A1 refers to a tubular design made for play calls and is directed more for competitive sports and for hiding information from other teams. The motivational bib kit of the present invention, in contrast, is to display a name or phrase on the chest or other parts of the athlete's clothing during sports, including but not limited to, running and road races like marathons or half marathons. The use is to encourage the spectators to read the name and or phrase and shout out to motivate and encourage the runners during the road race.

[0009] US20210181790 A1 is directed towards a reversible display band used by teams to communicate with each other. However, the Motivational Bib Kit of the present invention includes letters that are meant to be very visible. It includes letters that are meant to be read by many people, not only the team and its teammates. It's meant to be read by spectators in the crowd, by race announcers, and everybody around the athlete for encouragement.

[0010] US20190318216 A1 describes the assembly and manufacturing of a racing bib with the technical chip that reads the start time finish time and milestones in between for racing. This is what generally races will use for timekeeping as well as numbers for each of the individual athletes. The Motivational Bib Kit of the present invention is fundamentally different because the

timing bib does not claim to give any motivational attributes to its bib, only a timing chip mechanism. The Motivational Bib Kit allows the athlete to display a name and/or a phrase that they choose and is separate from the timing capabilities of the race kit or race bib that is currently given to them by the race organizers.

[0011] US 2017/0011668 A1 describes a series of character presentation panels using dense hook interfaces for equestrian purposes. The motivational bib kit of the present invention is fundamentally different because it is reversible in capability and allows users to use both sides of the material to display characters such as letters, numbers and graphics which US 2017/0011668 A1 does not allow for.

[0012] In addition to apparel, athletes find any method of getting motivation, emotional boosts or increase confidence that they can. Hearing your name or motivating phrase called out is an encouragement strategy for athletes. Sporting competitions get mentally tough on the athletes and require persistence, resilience, and grit to last the entire sporting event. Athletes often need to dig deep and find any motivational stimulus that will help them persist through their athletic pursuit. During a running race, for example, runners get increasingly tired as they run longer distances. This invention allows athletes to encourage the spectators of the sporting event to yell their name or motivational phrase of choice to help inspire and invigorate the athlete. Also, since the display material can hold letters and numbers on both sides (front and back), they can decide to switch the message or name if they choose.

[0013] However, conventional methods and supplies have many limitations, such as: [0014] Illegible text on the shirt. [0015] Flimsy or delicate materials that do not stay on apparel. [0016] Ruins the apparel for the participants or athletes. [0017] Is not reversible. [0018] Limits the race organizers from including every participant in having their name or phrase on race bibs. [0019] In addition, current methods and devices are not reversible, limiting the athlete of choices on what to put on their shirt.

[0020] One of the problems the present invention is solving is the ability to clearly and legibly display words and phrases on an athlete's body. Current methods athletes are using include permanent markers or duct tape (See FIGS. 5 and 6, by way of example). Often the permanent marker makes the shirt undesirable to use again.

[0021] Athletes have also used permanent marker to write on their arm (see FIG. 7, by way of example) so that their names are visible to their crowds. However, if there is any sort of weather like rain or snow or it is unusually hot and there's unusual amount of sweating or it is unusually hot and there's unusual amount of sweating the permanent marker is not very visible and usually handwriting on skin is not visible as well. The end result of using permanent markers on the skin is not desirable. It does not meet the athlete's goal of legibly showing their name to the crowds and it is not durable and will not hold up in many different conditions. In addition, having a permanent marker on your shirt will make the shirt unusable or very unfashionable for other uses.

[0022] Athletes also have used duct tape to try to spell their name on their shirt using configurations of duct tape on their shirt. Duct tape is not very sturdy under rainy or snowy conditions on cloth and race shirt material and often duct tape does not stay put for the duration of the race. Therefore, using duct tape does not meet the athlete's goal of having their name displayed on their shirt and/or body throughout the race and in the case of a marathon you want the name to be displayed throughout the entire 26.2 miles. The end of the race is the toughest time for runners and that is where they need encouragement. That is when you and the athletes want the most durable product for displaying your name on your shirt or body.

[0023] FIG. 5 depicts the problem with putting duct tape on your shirt; it does not hold and the letters can fall off if there is inclement weather or it's an unusually hot and sweaty day.

[0024] FIG. 6 depicts the problem using a marker to write on your shirt. You can see here that the name is pretty thin and also you have ruined the shirt and not everyone will want to wear the shirt that has your name written on it.

[0025] FIG. 7 depicts an athlete writing words on their arm. However, it is difficult to really see it and people are not usually able to see people's limbs when running fast going by a crowd.

[0026] Additionally, currently methods that race organizers offer to add participant's name to race bibs require the participants to sign up by a certain deadline to be included in the printing of the bibs. This causes a group of participants to be excluded from having their names printed on the bib if the deadline is missed. For example, if the deadline to sign up with a name is January 1, everyone who signs up for the event after January 1 will not be able to have their name put on their bib. This causes participants to feel excluded and not experience the custom experience events want to provide to their athletes. The reason for this deadline problem is the fact that the names have various lead times from the bib printers.

[0027] The Motivational Race Bib Kit of the present invention can solve these and other problems with conventional systems and methods by creating a legible, easy to use, removable, reversible, reconfigurable, and ready to use set of supplies for participants to add their name or phrase to their apparel. To achieve this functionality, the present invention provides reconfigurable, reversible, alpha-numeric adhesive decals applied to a waterproof and tear proof bib that can be attached to the athlete's body that can be used to pass output information to spectators about the athlete. Events can then allow any participant to put their names on their shirt no matter what timeline it is before the event starts.

SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

[0028] The present invention is directed at race bibs for use in sporting competitions where race bibs are visible on the athlete's body. More specifically, the present invention relates to reconfigurable, reversible, alphanumeric adhesive decals (or other alphanumeric display methods) on a waterproof and tear proof bib (or other display method), designed to be attached across an athlete's body, on a shirt/jersey during a sporting event.

[0029] These and other features, aspects and advantages of the present invention will become better understood with reference to the following drawings, description and claims.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0030] FIG. 1 depicts a preferred embodiment of a race bib kit assembled in accordance with the present invention.

[0031] FIG. 2 depicts a preferred embodiment of a race bib kit being worn by an athlete in accordance with the present invention.

[0032] FIG. 3 depicts a preferred embodiment of a race bib kit assembled and attached to clothing in accordance with the present invention.

[0033] FIG. 4 depicts the reversibility of the bib, showing the ability to have multiple messages on the same material

[0034] FIGS. 5, 6 and 7 depict prior art methods and devices.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF THE INVENTION

[0035] The following detailed description is of the best currently contemplated modes of carrying out exemplary embodiments of the invention. The description is not to be taken in a limiting sense but is made merely for the purpose of illustrating the general principles of the invention, since the scope of the invention is best defined by the appended claims.

[0036] The present invention is set forth in the following description, is shown in the drawings and is particularly and distinctly pointed out and set forth in the appended claims. The accompanying drawings, which are fully incorporated herein and constitute a part of the specification, illustrate various examples, methods, and other example embodiments of various aspects of the disclosure. All illustrations of the drawings are for the purpose of describing the present invention and are not

intended to limit the scope of the present invention.

[0037] FIG. 1 depicts a motivational race bib kit **100** assembled in accordance with a preferred embodiment of the present invention. Bib **10A** can be made of various materials, including, but not limited to, synthetic paper, cloth, adhesive tape, vinyl etc. that is able to hold letters and numbers **10C** on both sides of the bib **10A**. Bib **10A** can be attached to the runner via one or more fasteners **10B**. The fasteners **10B** can be, but not limited to, safety pins, adhesives, plugs or other types of fasteners. Bib **10A** also includes lettering **10C** that is used to spell out the name or phrase or words of the athlete's choice. The materials for the letters include, but are not limited to stencil, vinyl, adhesive, marker, paint, temporary tattoo etc.

[0038] FIG. 2 depicts a motivational race bib kit **100** as worn by an athlete in accordance with a preferred embodiment of the present invention. This figure shows the bib kit **100** on the runner's front shirt or chest. Other places that the bib kit can be are the arm, or leg or any visible body part so that spectators can read the lettering as the athlete passes by.

[0039] FIG. 3 depicts a motivational race bib kit **300** attached to clothing in accordance with a preferred embodiment of the present invention. As seen in FIG. 3, lettering **30A** is used to spell out the name or phrase or words of the athlete's choice. The materials for the letters include, but not limited to stencil, vinyl, adhesive, marker, paint, temporary tattoo etc. In this example, bib **30B** can be made of various materials including, but not limited to, synthetic paper, cloth, adhesive tape, vinyl etc. As seen in FIG. 3, in this example, bib **30B** is attached to a shirt **30C**, and the bib **30B** can be attached anywhere on the shirt, on the arm, on the back, or the front.

[0040] The reconfigurable bib **30B** is designed with holes that are punched out for the purpose of mounting the bib on the athlete's body using fasteners, usually across the chest or torso. The alphanumeric decals **30A** are removable so that the bib can be changed to say a different name or motivational phrase at additional sporting events or if the athlete changes their mind.

[0041] FIG. 4 depicts the material to which the alphanumeric decals or similar materials would be attached to. As seen in FIG. 4, the decals can be attached to either a front side **40A** or the rear side **40B**. In other words, both sides (**40A** and **40B**) are usable to create the motivational message or name, making the bib reversible and usable on both sides. The reconfigurable bib **400** is designed with holes that are punched out for the purpose of mounting the bib on the athlete's body using fasteners, usually across the chest or torso. The alphanumeric decals are removable so that the bib can be changed to say a different name or motivational phrase at additional sporting events or if the athlete changes their mind.

[0042] Synthetic paper bibs are one type of display method for the kit. As seen by way of example in FIGS. 1-4, the bib includes four punctures to accommodate attachments such as safety pins or big pins so that the athlete can attach it to their shirt or apparel. In a preferred embodiment, the bib material is synthetic woven paper that is meant to deter from ripping, getting ruined in wet environments and be able to last through long periods of time.

[0043] There are many other different displays that could be incorporated into the kit of the present invention, including, but not limited to: [0044] LCD Display [0045] Paper-synthetic or natural paper [0046] Electronic paper-electronic displays using e-ink [0047] Holographic-imaging technology that displays holographic imagery that can be used on both the front and back.

[0048] An example of alphanumeric displays are sets of stickers or adhesive backed alphabets and numeric adhesives included in the bib kit. This allows the athlete to customize what they put on the bib ranging from their name to a phrase such as 'CINDY' or 'My 1st marathon' or 'Go CINDY GO!' The material used is usually vinyl stick-ons to help prevent tearing or ripping and which can last through wet environments. The letters and adhesives can be of any size but on average, in the United States, names consist of 6 to 7 letters. Therefore, the average size of adhesive we offer is 2 inches tall. Additionally having 2-inch-tall letters allows spectators to see the letters from 20 feet away. The maximum distance this can be seen is 50 feet. Given that spectators are looking at the athletes and anticipating them passing by the motivational bib kit gives spectators a better

opportunity to spot athletes far away and also decreases the chance that they misread the name or miss it completely.

[0049] There are many different alphanumeric displays that can be used in connection with the kit of the present invention. Such displays can include: [0050] Vinyl adhesive [0051] Paper—synthetic or natural paper [0052] Adhesive shaped in alphabets and numbers [0053] Stencils [0054] Markers [0055] The means for determining the number of letters to be sent in each package is also innovative. Statistical pattern recognition, historical analysis, General population demographics, historical Marathon participants can and have been used to determine the proper number of letters and numbers to include in the kit in order to fit the majority of the population. As referenced above, in the United States, names consist of 6 to 7 letters on average and so the kit can include space for up to 9 letters and include 2 sets of the English alphabet in order to serve the population. As more data around the needs for the population of athletes is gathered, more predictive analytics and artificial intelligence can be applied to further serve the market of athletes and clients.

[0056] Safety pins are examples of fasteners that can be used to attach the bib kit to the athlete's shirt or apparel. Safety pins are the most common form of attachment tool but are not limited to just safety pins. There are many different fastening means that can be used in connection with the kit of the present invention including, but not limited to: [0057] Physical [0058] Adhesive [0059] Magnetic

[0060] It should be understood, of course, that the foregoing relates to exemplary embodiments of the invention and that modifications may be made without departing from the spirit and scope of the invention as set forth in the following claims.

Claims

1. A reversible and customizable race bib kit for use by a participant in a sporting event, the kit comprising: a race bib having a front surface, a rear surface and one or more attachment holes therethrough; lettering that can be removably attached to the front surface and the rear surface of the race bib; and one or more fasteners for removably attaching the race bib to a participant.
2. The reversible and customizable race bib kit of claim 1, wherein the race bib is made from a material selected from the group of materials consisting of cloth, paper, synthetic or electronic material.
3. The reversible and customizable race bib kit of claim 1, wherein the lettering is made from a material selected from the group of materials consisting of adhesive materials, stencil, or electronic imaging that can be combined to spell out names, phrases or similar characters relating to the participant.
4. The reversible and customizable race bib kit of claim 1, wherein the fasteners are selected from the group of fasteners consisting of adhesives, magnets, clips, strings, pins or similar materials or devices for attaching the bib to the participant.
5. A wearable, reversible, customizable, personally identifiable information broadcast device kit that allows sports spectators to identify a sports participant comprising: a) a display surface comprising cloth, paper, synthetic material, electronic or similar surfaces that can display alphanumeric characters or images; b) one or more fasteners for removably attaching the display surface to a participant, the fasteners comprising adhesive, magnetic, clips, hardware or containers; c) lettering comprising adhesive materials, stencil, or electronic imaging that can be removably attached or otherwise displayed on the front or rear of the display surface and combined to spell out names, phrases or similar characters.
6. A wearable, reversible, customizable, personally identifiable information broadcast method that allows sports spectators to identify a sports participant comprising: a) a display surface comprising cloth, paper, synthetic material, electronic or similar surfaces that will display alphanumeric characters or images on its front or rear surfaces; b) one or more fasteners comprising adhesive,

magnetic, clips, hardware or containers that are applied to surfaces and attaches the device to surfaces; c) lettering comprising adhesive materials, stencil, or electronic imaging that can be combined to spell out names, phrases or similar characters.

7. A wearable, reversible, customizable, personally identifiable information broadcast system that allows sports spectators to identify a sports participant comprising: a) a display surface comprising cloth, paper, synthetic material, electronic or similar surfaces that will display alphanumeric characters or images on its front or rear surfaces; b) one or more fasteners comprising adhesive, magnetic, clips, hardware or containers that are applied to surfaces and attaches the device to surfaces; c) lettering comprising adhesive materials, stencil, or electronic imaging that can be combined to spell out names, phrases or similar characters.
